

19 — Online E-commerce & Mini Importation

China sourcing · WhatsApp · Instagram · Jumia · 2026

Medium capital (test batches) · Physical products · Local demand

How to source small batches of products (mainly from China) and sell them profitably in Nigeria via social commerce and marketplaces. Covers product selection, sourcing platforms, shipping, selling channels and realistic first-order math.

1. What This Hustle Is

You identify products Nigerians already buy, order small quantities (10–50 units) from Chinese suppliers, bring them into Nigeria, and sell through WhatsApp, Instagram, TikTok, Jiji, Jumia or a simple store. Unlike pure dropshipping, you hold a small amount of stock so you control quality, delivery speed and customer experience. Margins of 2–5× landed cost are common on the right products.

2. Realistic Capital & Returns

Stage	Capital needed	Realistic outcome
First test order	■20k–■80k	Learn process + first profit or lessons
Validated product	■100k–■300k	Consistent restocks + ■100k–■400k/mo
Scaled operation	■500k+	Multiple SKUs + ■500k–■2m+/mo

A well-chosen ■20k–■50k first order can return ■50k–■120k in sales if the product moves. The biggest risks are choosing the wrong product, underestimating shipping/customs, and slow sales velocity.

3. Product Selection Rules

- Strong existing demand on Jiji, Instagram, WhatsApp groups or physical markets
- Good margin after product + shipping + any duty (aim 2.5×+ landed cost)
- Not heavily restricted (avoid complex NAFDAC/SON categories at the start)
- Easy to photograph and demonstrate (phone accessories, beauty, home, fashion items often work)
- Lightweight enough for reasonable air-freight cost on small batches

4. Sourcing Platforms

- **1688.com** — cheapest factory prices (Chinese interface; use translate + agent)
- **AliExpress** — easiest English interface for first test orders
- **Alibaba** — better for larger validated orders and Trade Assurance
- Use a trusted freight forwarder / agent for ordering, consolidation and Nigeria clearance

5. Selling Channels That Convert in Nigeria

1. WhatsApp Business + catalog — still the highest conversion channel for many sellers
2. Instagram / TikTok — product demos and lifestyle content
3. Jiji — wide reach for tested demand
4. Jumia / Konga — extra distribution once you have volume and reviews
5. Simple own store (Flutterwave, Shopify, or Instagram Shopping) later

6. First-Order Process

1. Validate demand (search Jiji/Instagram, check competing prices).
2. Find supplier + calculate landed cost (product + shipping + agent + buffer).
3. Place small test order (10–30 units).
4. Clear goods, photograph well, list on WhatsApp + Instagram + Jiji.
5. Sell, collect feedback, restock winners only.

7. Common Mistakes

- Ordering large quantities of an untested product.
- Ignoring total landed cost and duty.
- Poor product photos and weak product demonstration.
- No clear customer communication or delivery timelines.

- Mixing personal and business money with no simple tracking.

8. 30–45 Day Path

Days 1–10: Niche + product research + supplier shortlist. Days 11–25: First test order + shipping. Days 26–45: Receive, list, sell, decide restock or pivot.

9. Action Checklist

- Product idea validated with local demand evidence
- Landed-cost calculation done
- Supplier + freight forwarder chosen
- First small test order placed
- WhatsApp Business + Instagram ready for sales
- Simple tracking of cost, sales and profit

Companion resources in matching JSON. FinReels Online Hustle package.
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